Sylvia

by Akoo

How to use your 12-month investing plan

A plain-English, step-by-step guide for beginners.
Every page, every tool, and the Graham lessons built in.

Educational plan, not a promise of returns. Not financial advice. Your data stays in your own browser.

Welcome to Sylvia

Sylvia is a free planner that teaches you to invest carefully over twelve months. You learn first, practise on paper, and only then (if you choose) put a small amount of real money at risk.

> **What Sylvia is not**
> It does not give investment advice, predict prices or promise profit. You can finish all twelve months without making money and still have succeeded, if you learned, protected your capital and followed your rules.

The big idea in one paragraph

Most beginners lose money by moving too fast: buying tips, watching prices all day and risking too much on one idea. Sylvia slows you down. It gives you a written plan, a checklist for each stage, and tools that stop you when you are about to break your own rules. It also teaches the ideas of Benjamin Graham, author of *The Intelligent Investor*, in 28 short lessons that are built into the tools.

Before you start

- **Open the site** in any modern browser: https://olayiwolaabdulwarith740-jpg.github.io/musical-octo-succotash/
- **Use the same browser and device each time.** Sylvia saves your work inside that browser only. Nothing is sent anywhere.
- **Do not clear site data** for the page, or your progress goes with it. Back up often (see Settings in the Reference section).
- **Time needed:** about 45 to 60 minutes a day at full pace. Consistency beats volume.

Your 12-month map

Stage	When	What you do
Phase 0 · Setup	Week 0	Read the restrictions, sign your contract with yourself, set up accounts and tools.
Phase 1 · Foundation	Months 1-3	Learn how markets and orders work. Keep a daily routine.
Phase 2 · Analysis	Months 4-6	Read companies, charts and your own biases. Build theses.
Investor type	After Phase 2	Find out whether you are a Defensive or Enterprising investor.
Phase 3 · Risk	Months 7-9	Position sizing, loss limits, allocation policy and a signed written plan.
Phase 4 · Small live test	Months 10-12	Optional. Follow your rules with up to $500 of real money.

1 Getting around

The menu, the dashboard and the top bar

The left menu

Everything lives in the menu on the left. On a phone, tap the round menu button at the top right to open it. The menu has five groups:

Group	Pages inside	What it is for
(top)	Dashboard	Your home screen: next step, progress and warnings.
Phases	0 Setup, 1 Foundation, 2 Analysis, Investor type, 3 Risk, 4 Small live test	The twelve-month course, in order.
Practice	Trade Journal, Metrics, Thesis Builder, Position Calculator, Watchlist, Weekly Review	Where you record and review your decisions.
Graham	Investment or speculation, Margin of safety, Defensive screener, Mr. Market, Allocation policy, Graham lessons	The tools from *The Intelligent Investor*.
Reference	Red Flags, Resources, Glossary, Plan Report (PDF), Settings	Look-ups, your report and your data controls.

The dashboard

- **Month banner:** which month of twelve you are in, and your current phase.
- **Your next step:** a green box that names the single most useful thing to do now. Press **Open it** to jump there.
- **Phase track:** five circles showing how much of each phase you have finished.
- **Red flags:** a pink box appears if something needs attention. It always says what to do.
- **Graham check:** four small tiles (investment vs speculation, portfolio margin of safety, defensive criteria passed, forecasting caught) plus your two limits.
- **Today's routine:** tick the box once you have done your daily study. This is a streak for study, never for trading.
- **Study and review days:** a 12-week map of the days you studied. Trades are not counted: a quiet week can be a good week.

Top bar

- The **phase badge** shows where you are.
- The **round button** switches between light and dark mode.

2 The phases, step by step

Work through them in order

Phase 0 · Setup (week 0)

- Read the **restrictions** and tick that you have read them. They include rules such as: no borrowed money, no tips, and keep speculation to a small capped amount.
- Work through the **setup checklist** (brokerage research, tools, news sources).
- Read **the two pots** card: your money is split into an investment pot and a small speculation pot.
- **Sign your contract** with yourself: type your name and the date. It is a promise to follow the plan.

Phase 1 · Foundation (months 1-3)

- Tick the **milestones** as you learn how markets, orders and risk work, and add a note to each.
- Use the **daily log** to record what you studied.
- Take the **quiz** when you feel ready.

Phase 2 · Analysis (months 4-6)

- Add companies (press **Add company**) and fill in what you find: revenue trend, debt level, cash generation.
- Each company card has a **Graham section** with the screener (see the Graham tools section). Turn on the **Graham lens** to show the extra checks everywhere.
- A **peer table** compares your companies side by side: score, balance-sheet strength, Graham Number and margin of safety.
- Use the **bias log** to write down when your emotions pushed you.

Investor type

Take this short assessment after Phase 2. Sylvia defaults you to **Defensive**: the careful, low-effort path, with fewer decisions and a simpler routine. You are only labelled **Enterprising** if you answer all three questions at the top level, commit to **10 or more hours a week**, and write your commitment. Being Defensive is not a lesser result. For most people it is the right one.

Phase 3 · Risk (months 7-9)

- Use the **allocation tool** to set your stock and defensive split and see when to rebalance.
- Fill in and **sign the written trading plan**.
- The **heat** panel adds up how much of your capital is at risk across open positions.
- Read the **stop-loss caveat**: stops can protect you but can also sell good holdings at bad moments.

Phase 4 · Small live test (months 10-12)

This phase is optional, and Defensive investors may skip it. Complete the **readiness checklist**, then choose whether to try real money, with a hard maximum of **$500**. Every live trade must say which of your two limits it meets (see Your two limits section). Press **Advance** on a phase to move to the next one when you are done.

3 Your daily practice tools

Journal, thesis, calculator, watchlist, metrics, weekly review

Trade Journal

Every trade, paper or live, gets an entry. Press **Add a trade** and fill in the form.

Field	What to enter
Mode	**Paper** (pretend) or **Live** (real money, Phase 4 only).
Classification	**Investment, speculation or unclear.** Required. Unclear counts as speculation.
Margin of safety at entry	How far below your estimate of value you paid. Can be negative.
Price influenced decision	Honestly say whether the price movement, not your thesis, pushed you.
Meets your limits	For live trades: how it meets your minimum return and maximum loss.
Entry, exit, size, costs	The numbers. Results are worked out for you once there is an exit price.
Idea source	Where the idea came from. Tips and hot stocks raise a red flag.

Use **Filter** to find entries, and **Export CSV** to open them in a spreadsheet. A violation of your own rules is recorded, not hidden.

Thesis Builder

A thesis is a written reason for an investment. Write what the business does, why it is worth more than the price, what could go wrong, and what would make you sell. Pick a decision: **Watch, Buy or Pass**. Sylvia will not let you mark **Buy** until the review checks are done, including the **skeptic check** (argue against yourself) and, for growth stories, a note of what growth you are assuming and why.

Position Calculator (optional)

Type your capital, the percentage you will risk, and the entry and stop prices. It shows how many shares keep the possible loss within your limit.

Watchlist

A parking place for ideas you are not ready to buy. Add a ticker, choose a category with the **category buttons**, and write why it interests you. Nothing here is a trade.

Metrics

Once you have closed trades, Metrics shows net result, win rate, profit factor and drawdown, plus Graham measures such as how often you followed your thesis rather than the price. Early on, expect an empty screen. That is normal.

Weekly Review

Once a week, answer the questions about what you did, what you learned and whether your decisions were **businesslike**. The businesslike percentage is a way to judge decisions on quality, not on profit. Press **End review** to save it.

4 The Graham tools

Seven pages built from The Intelligent Investor

Investment or speculation

Answer seven short questions about an idea. Sylvia says **investment**, **speculation** or **unclear**. If it says unclear, treat it as speculation until you can show otherwise. Use **Clear** to start again.

Margin of safety

The gap between what you pay and what the business is reasonably worth. It protects you from your own mistakes. Type four numbers per share and the result updates as you type:

Input	Example
Current price	$40
Normalized earnings per share (an average year, not the best one)	$4
Book value per share	$25
Required return a year	8%

Sylvia then shows three anchors: the **asset floor** (what the balance sheet holds), **earnings power** ($4 divided by 8% = $50) and the **Graham Number** (the square root of 22.5 x earnings x book value = $47.43, a ceiling, not a target). The value range is $47.43 to $50.00, the price is $40, so the margin is about **16%**, labelled **moderate**. You can also load a saved company with **Load from a saved company**.

> **Careful**
> This is a teaching tool. It shows how far a price sits from three anchors; it does not predict returns. The 15% and 33% cut-offs are this app's teaching thresholds, not rules from the book. If the answer looks too good, check you used normalized earnings.

Defensive screener

A checklist of eight tests that a cautious investor would want a company to pass: size, strong finances, a record of earnings, a record of dividends, earnings growth, a reasonable price against earnings, and a reasonable price against assets. Fill in the figures on each company card and watch the **score out of 8**, the progress ring and the pass or fail for each test update live. The page keeps a history of your pass rate.

Enterprising screener

This only unlocks if you are labelled Enterprising. It adds the extra tests, including a **net-net** calculation (current assets minus all debts, compared with the price).

Mr. Market

Graham imagined the market as a moody business partner who offers prices every day. His mood is no reason for you to act. Each day, record the market's mood, your mood, and whether the price influenced you. Press **Timing temptation** every time you feel the urge to guess where prices will go. Count it, don't act on it. The two-line chart helps you see whether your mood follows the market's.

Allocation policy

- Choose a **stock percentage between 25% and 75%**; the rest is defensive (high-quality bonds or cash).
- Choose how to rebalance: when it drifts by a number of points (the **band**), or on a **calendar**.
- Enter what you hold. Example: $6,200 in stocks and $3,800 defensive at a 50/50 target means **sell $1,200 of stocks and buy $1,200 of defensive**.
- The **steady-investing planner** shows what regular deposits could add up to under 5 different growth scenarios (minus 3% to plus 9% a year). $200 a month for 10 years is $24,000 put in; at 6% a year the illustration reaches about $32,495. It is an illustration, not a forecast.

Graham lessons

All 28 lessons in plain words, grouped by topic. Each lesson also tells you which Sylvia feature enforces it, so you can see the idea at work. Mark a lesson as read to track your progress.

5 Your two limits and the speculation cap

Rules that keep you safe

Before any live trade, Sylvia needs two numbers from you in **Settings**:

- **Minimum acceptable return** a year, the least you would be happy with.
- **Maximum acceptable permanent loss**, as a percentage of your capital. This is the loss you could take without it changing your life.

> **Sylvia's rule**
> A live trade is blocked until both limits are set, and every live trade must say how it meets them.

The speculation cap

Live speculation, and live trades marked unclear, count against a **sandbox cap**, a small amount you set (the most it can be is $500). If a new trade would take you over it, Sylvia shows a hard warning and asks you to confirm. If you go ahead, the trade is logged as a violation: *Speculation above the sandbox cap*. Paper trades do not count against the cap, so you can practise freely.

Red Flags

The Red Flags page lists warning signs, some you tick yourself and some **detected from your data**: for example interest coverage under 3 times, a growth story with no limit, too many timing temptations, or a trade that came from a tip. A flag always tells you what to do next. The usual advice is: stop, write down what happened, check the evidence and return to paper trading if needed.

The 28 lessons at a glance

Topic	Lessons	Where you meet them
Investment vs speculation	1, 3, 27, 28	Classifier, limits, cap, restrictions
Analysis and price	2, 4, 5, 15, 17	Thesis gate, margin of safety, peer table
Behaviour	7, 8, 9, 26	Mr. Market, timing counter, weekly review
Knowing yourself	10, 14	Investor type
Company quality	6, 11, 13, 16, 18-22	Screeners, record, dividends, growth, earnings quality
Portfolio	12, 23, 24, 25	Concentration monitor, allocation, steady investing, stop-loss caveat

6 Reference and your data

Report, glossary, settings and backups

Glossary

Plain-English meanings for every term. Use the **search box**, or add your own words with **Add term**.

Resources

Reading lists and sources for further study.

Plan Report (PDF)

Builds a printable summary of your plan, progress and Graham answers. Press **Print**, then choose **Save as PDF** in the print window.

Settings

- **Profile:** name, start date, goal and the loss you can bear.
- **Graham card:** your two limits, the speculation cap and the size threshold.
- **Theme:** light or dark.
- **Export JSON:** downloads all your data as a backup file.
- **Import JSON:** loads a backup. Older backups are brought up to date automatically.
- **Reset all:** erases everything. It cannot be undone, so export first.

> **Tip**
> Export a JSON backup once a week, after your weekly review. If you use a new phone or computer, import the file there. Progress does not move between devices by itself.

Your privacy

Sylvia runs entirely in your browser. It has no account, no tracking and makes no network calls. Anything you type stays on your device.

A simple weekly routine

Day	Do this (about 45 to 60 minutes)
Every day	Read reputable news for 20-30 minutes. Check open positions and risk limits for 10-15. Update the journal for 5-10. Tick today's routine. Do not check prices all day.
Once a week	Complete the Weekly Review. Log Mr. Market's mood. Export a JSON backup.
Each new idea	Classify it, write the thesis, calculate the margin of safety, run the screener, and only then decide.

7 Questions and fixes

Common problems, and a last word

Problem	Fix
My data disappeared	You are probably in a different browser, a private window, or cleared site data. Go back to the original browser, or import your JSON backup.
I don't see the Graham menu	Do a hard refresh: hold Shift and click reload (on a phone use a private tab). GitHub can take a few minutes to update.
The page says 404	Wait a minute or two and refresh. GitHub Pages must be switched on in the repository settings.
The Enterprising screener is locked	This is on purpose. Take the Investor type assessment. Defensive is the default.
I can't mark a thesis as Buy	Complete the review fields, including the skeptic check.
My live trade won't save	Set both limits in Settings, choose a classification, and say how it meets your limits.
Results show zero or empty	Add an exit price to a trade. Metrics only count closed trades.
Buttons are hard to see	Switch to dark or light mode with the round button at the top right.

A last word from the plan

Judge the year by the quality of your decisions, the consistency of your risk controls, your understanding of what you own and your honesty about the evidence. A profitable trade that broke your rules can teach a dangerous habit, and a planned loss can be the right result of a disciplined decision. The goal is not to trade more. It is to decide better and protect what you have.

Sylvia is an educational plan, not a promise of returns, and nothing in it is financial advice. Talk to a qualified professional before putting real money at risk.

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